

Key Pain Points in Using RTI in India

1. Low awareness and complexity of filing: Many citizens do not know their RTI rights or how to identify the correct authority, making the process intimidating and confusing.
2. Procedural and cost barriers: Multiple state-specific rules, different fee/payment modes, and the need to travel or pay fees create financial and time costs, especially for rural and low-income users.
3. Poor-quality or incomplete responses: Information provided is often partial, irrelevant, or delayed, forcing users to file repeat applications.
4. Delays, backlog, and weak enforcement: RTI applications and appeals face long processing times, with huge backlogs in Information Commissions and very low rates of penalty against defaulting officials.
5. Bureaucratic resistance and harassment: Many officials treat RTI as a threat, leading to non-cooperation, repeated requests, hostile behaviour, and in extreme cases intimidation or violence against information seekers.
6. Poor record management and limited proactive disclosure: Weak record-keeping and non-compliance with Section 4(1)(b) mean citizens must file RTIs even for basic information that should already be public.
7. Fragmented digital infrastructure: Uneven or outdated online RTI systems, lack of unified case tracking, and limited digital literacy make it hard for citizens to file and track applications digitally.
8. Legal and structural dilution: Amendments to the RTI Act and overlapping data protection/privacy rules have reduced the independence of Information Commissions and expanded grounds for denying information.